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Maths puzzles for early finishers

Early Finisher Puzzles

Primary 3

Semester 1

Terms 1 and 2

20 single-page puzzles
Almost every puzzle checks itself
One star and two star pages
Teacher answer key included

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Notes

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Teacher notes (DRAFT)

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What this is

Twenty single-page maths puzzles for Primary 3 pupils who finish their work early. This is Semester 1 of two booklets (Terms 1 and 2). Each page stands alone, so you can hand out one page or keep a tray of pages. The pupil needs no help to start.

Which terms

The pages are grouped by the order in which Primary 3 topics are typically taught: this booklet follows Terms 1 and 2, the other booklet follows Semester 2 (Terms 3 and 4). Schools vary, so check your scheme of work: use a page whenever its topic has been taught, from either booklet.

Stars

One star pages practise a topic as it is usually taught (10 pages). Two star pages use the same topics with two steps or two clues to combine (10 pages).

How the pages check themselves

The boxed strip at the foot of each page tells the pupil how to check. The check shows that something is wrong. It does not give the answer, and it asks the pupil to see whether the answer makes sense. Every answer box and every letter box must be filled: a box left blank gives no letter, and the check cannot see it.

- **Code word.** The answers give letters that spell a word. The strip gives no hint of the word. Each word can be spelt from its letters in one way only, so answers in the wrong boxes never make another word, and one or two wrong answers very rarely do. A box left empty gives no letter and is not seen by the check.
- **Colour by code.** Each answer is found in a key of five numbers and the part is coloured with that crayon. The pupil counts the parts of each colour and compares with the box on the page; matching parts must share a colour.
- **Route.** The line must reach FINISH through the stated number of boxes, and every box on it must follow the rule on the page.
- **Letters in an order, a grid or a choice.** Each number, card, picture or choice carries a letter; the letters, read in the order asked, must spell a word. Where one item is left out, its letter is a decoy that is not part of the word.
- **Loop.** The numbers on touching tiles must match all the way round the loop.

Marking is not needed. To spot-check, look only at the check strip.

How the checks were tested

A script tried every single wrong answer and every wrong arrangement on every page. Each check rejected at least 95% of them. A wrong answer that spells any of about 262 000 English words counts as not rejected. Two wrong answers at once were not all tested.

Teacher notes: using the pages (DRAFT)

Using the pages

- **Time.** Most pages take 5 to 15 minutes; the colour-by-code pages (S1-14) take longer because pupils colour a picture. Pupils need their own crayons (five colours: yellow, red, blue, green, orange). For a pencil-only copy the pupil writes Y, R, B, G or O in each part; the tally and the matching parts are checked the same way. Light crayons work best: a dark crayon hides the number in the part on a photocopy.
- **If the check fails.** The pupil goes back, looks for the slip, and asks a friend or you if still stuck.
- **Stars.** One star: one skill, as usually taught. Two stars: the same topics with two steps or two clues to combine.
- **Drawings.** Pictures of rulers, scales, clocks, coins and notes are original drawings, not to scale unless a page says so. Coins and notes are inspired by Singapore money, not actual size (smaller than real) and in black and white.

Photocopying

All pages are black and white with solid lines, so they copy cleanly. Use normal toner, not a light setting: on the page with coins and notes (Money Sums, S1-20) a light setting can fill in the small word cents on the coins. Each page is one side only. Pupils write on the page: the boxes are large for young hands. Use A4 and print at 100% (actual size).

Pictures are not actual size. Real $2 notes are purple, $5 green, $10 red.

What a printed page cannot check

Real measuring (a ruler, a jug, a scale, a stopwatch) cannot be done on paper: the pages show drawn scales, containers, dials and stopwatch faces to read, and the pupil reads them. The idea of an angle is met by comparing drawn angles with a right angle. Drawing perpendicular and parallel lines (Draw the Lines, S2-16) is checked only through the letter where the drawn line ends, so look at the lines if you wish. Mental calculation cannot be enforced on a page: the route and code pages ask for answers, not for the method. Figures with marked lengths are drawn to scale on the page, but pictures are not actual size.

Contents: Semester 1

Page	Code	Puzzle	Tier
S1-01	P3-01	Place Value	1 star
S1-02	P3-02	Words and Numbers	1 star
S1-03	P3-03	Digit Cards	2 stars
S1-04	P3-04	Compare and Order	2 stars
S1-05	P3-05	Number Patterns	2 stars
S1-06	P3-06	Big Sums	1 star
S1-07	P3-07	Mental Pairs	1 star
S1-08	P3-08	Missing Digits	2 stars
S1-09	P3-09	Tables Maze	1 star
S1-10	P3-10	True or False Tables	1 star
S1-11	P3-11	Remainders	1 star
S1-12	P3-12	Fact Families	2 stars
S1-13	P3-13	Multiply and Divide	2 stars
S1-14	P3-14	Colour the Fish	2 stars
S1-15	P3-15	Equal Fractions	1 star
S1-16	P3-16	Simplest Form	1 star
S1-17	P3-17	Fraction Gaps	2 stars
S1-18	P3-18	Fraction Order	2 stars
S1-19	P3-19	Fraction Sums	2 stars
S1-20	P3-20	Money Sums	1 star

Pages are independent. The footer code shows the page in this booklet and, in brackets, its number in the full set of 40 (P3-01 to P3-40).

What the booklet covers

Whole Numbers 1.1 counting in hundreds/thousands **S1-01, S1-05**

Whole Numbers 1.2 number notation, representations and place values **S1-01, S1-03**

Whole Numbers 1.3 reading and writing numbers in numerals and in words **S1-02**

Whole Numbers 1.4 comparing and ordering numbers **S1-03, S1-04**

Whole Numbers 1.5 patterns in number sequences **S1-05**

Addition and Subtraction 2.1 addition and subtraction algorithms (up to 4 digits) **S1-06, S1-08**

Addition and Subtraction 2.2 mental calculation involving addition and subtraction of two 2-digit numbers **S1-07**

Multiplication and Division 3.1 multiplication tables of 6, 7, 8 and 9 **S1-09, S1-10, S1-12, S1-14**

Multiplication and Division 3.2 multiplying and dividing within the multiplication tables **S1-09, S1-10, S1-12, S1-14**

Multiplication and Division 3.3 division with remainder **S1-11**

Multiplication and Division 3.4 multiplication and division algorithms (up to 3 digits by 1 digit) **S1-13**

Multiplication and Division 3.5 mental calculation involving multiplication and division within the multiplication tables **S1-09, S1-10, S1-14**

Fractions 1.1 equivalent fractions **S1-15, S1-17, S1-18**

Fractions 1.2 simplest form **S1-16**

Fractions 1.3 comparing and ordering unlike fractions (denominators not exceeding 12) **S1-18**

Fractions 1.4 finding an equivalent fraction given the denominator or numerator **S1-17**

Fractions 2.1 adding and subtracting two related fractions within one whole **S1-19**

Money 1.1 adding and subtracting money in decimal notation **S1-20**

Outcomes practised in the other booklet: Length, Mass and Volume 1.1; Length, Mass and Volume 1.2; Length, Mass and Volume 1.3; Time 2.1; Time 2.2; Time 2.3; Area and Perimeter 1.1; Area and Perimeter 1.2; Area and Perimeter 1.3; Area and Perimeter 1.4; Angles 1.1; Angles 1.2; Perpendicular and Parallel Lines 2.1; Perpendicular and Parallel Lines 2.2; Bar Graphs 1.1; Bar Graphs 1.2.

S1-01 (P3-01)

Place Value

Name _____

Topic: Place value: thousands, hundreds, tens and ones, numbers to 10 000

Write the number in the box.
Use the code table.

1

Thousands	Hundreds	Tens	Ones
1000 1000 1000 1000	100	10 10 10	1 1

2

Thousands	Hundreds	Tens	Ones
1000 1000		10 10	1 1 1

3 How many hundreds are in 1400?

4 6 thousands, 14 hundreds and 6 ones make which number?

5 In 1567, what is the value of the digit 6?

6 7 thousands and 9 tens make which number?

Code table

14 = I	60 = E	2023 = U	2314 = C	4132 = Q
4607 = J	6704 = X	7090 = R	7406 = V	

Check it. Write the letters in order. Do they spell a word?

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S1-02 (P3-02)

Words and Numbers

★ Name _____

Topic: Reading and writing numbers in words and in numerals

Start at START. Move up, down, left or right.
Go to the box with the words for the number at the foot of your box.
Do not step on a box twice.

nine thousand seven hundred and thirty-nine **4390**	**FINISH** **four thousand three hundred and ninety** **2297**	**seven thousand four hundred and eighty-eight** **2369**	**two thousand two hundred and twenty-seven** **4704**
six thousand four hundred and forty-five **9739**	**seven thousand four hundred and eighty-eight** **6445**	**two thousand two hundred and twenty-seven** **7488**	**two thousand nine hundred and ninety-three** **2227**
nine thousand seven hundred and twenty-nine **4819**	**two thousand two hundred and thirty-seven** **3182**	**two thousand nine hundred and thirty-nine** **4521**	**eight thousand six hundred and thirty-five** **2993**
three thousand two hundred and twenty-seven **9503**	**seven thousand nine hundred and thirty-nine** **5616**	**three thousand and ninety-three** **6542**	**START** **seven thousand five hundred and seventy-five** **8635**

Check it. Does your line reach FINISH? Count its boxes: are there 8? Does each top word match?

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S1-03 (P3-03)

Digit Cards

★★ Name _____

Topic: Numbers to 10 000: make, compare and order numbers from digit cards

Use all four cards once each.
Make a 4-digit number. A number cannot start with 0.
Use the code table.

1

2	8	3	0

Make the greatest odd number.

2

6	9	8	1

Make the greatest number.

3

7	6	9	3

Make the greatest even number.

4

4	3	8	1

Make the smallest even number.

5

8	0	1	9

Make the smallest number.

6

6	9	3	1

Make the smallest odd number.

Code table

1089 = P	1348 = O	1369 = Y	3169 = J	8203 = C
8413 = Z	9637 = R	9736 = N	9861 = A	

Check it. Write the letters in order.
Do they spell a word?

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S1-04 (P3-04)

Compare and Order

★★ Name _____

Topic: Numbers to 10 000: comparing and ordering

Put each set of numbers in order.
Write the letter of each card in its place.
Set A: smallest first. Set B: greatest first.

Set A: smallest first.

2473	7234	7423
C	O	U

Set B: greatest first.

976	8054	7154
N	S	I

Write the letters in order: Set A, then Set B.

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

Check it. Read the six letters in order. Do they spell a word?

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S1-05 (P3-05)

Number Patterns

★★ Name _____

Topic: Number patterns: counting in hundreds and thousands, two-step patterns

Find the rule. Find the missing number.
Circle the letter beside the missing number.
Write the six letters in the boxes.

1. 8000 | 7000 | 6000 | 5000 | ? — 4000 (P) | 3900 (W) | 3990 (Q)

2. 2870 | 3070 | 3090 | ? | 3310 — 3290 (O) | 3390 (X) | 3270 (F)

3. 3870 | 3970 | 3980 | 4080 | ? — 4090 (L) | 4100 (V) | 4190 (J)

4. 2200 | 3200 | 4200 | ? | 6200 — 5100 (F) | 5210 (T) | 5200 (I)

5. 8700 | 8600 | ? | 8400 | 8300 — 9500 (J) | 8510 (Z) | 8500 (C)

6. 4500 | 4600 | 4700 | 4800 | ? — 5900 (N) | 4900 (E) | 5000 (Z)

Check it. Write the letters in order. Do they spell a word? ☐☐☐☐☐☐

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S1-06 (P3-06)

Big Sums

Name _____

Topic: Add and subtract in columns, 4-digit numbers

Work out each sum in columns.
Write the answer in the box.
Use the code table.

1

$$\begin{array}{r} 3651 \\ +\ 4226 \\ \hline \square \end{array}$$

2

$$\begin{array}{r} 5847 \\ -\ 3794 \\ \hline \square \end{array}$$

3

$$\begin{array}{r} 5605 \\ -\ 3816 \\ \hline \square \end{array}$$

4

$$\begin{array}{r} 6269 \\ -\ 2000 \\ \hline \square \end{array}$$

5

$$\begin{array}{r} 5254 \\ +\ 1820 \\ \hline \square \end{array}$$

6

$$\begin{array}{r} 5097 \\ +\ 1667 \\ \hline \square \end{array}$$

Code table

1789 = A	2053 = E	2063 = K	4269 = C	6764 = P
6864 = X	7074 = U	7877 = T	8877 = Q	

Check it. Write the letters in order. Do they spell a word? ☐☐☐☐☐☐

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S1-07 (P3-07)

Mental Pairs

Name _____

Topic: Mental sums: adding and subtracting two 2-digit numbers

Start at START. Move up, down, left or right.
Step only on boxes with the answer 48.
Do not step on a box twice.

FINISH 90 – 42	76 – 37	51 – 14	66 – 18
84 – 36	81 – 33	97 – 49	77 – 29
29 + 19	70 – 11	29 + 17	64 – 16
74 – 35	70 – 33	START 95 – 47	85 – 37

Check it. Does your line reach FINISH? Count its boxes: are there 8? Does every box make 48?

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S1-08 (P3-08)

Missing Digits

★★ Name _____

Topic: Add and subtract in columns: find the missing digit

One digit is missing from each sum.
Write the missing digit in the box.
Use the code table.

1

$$\begin{array}{r} 4\,9\,9\,7 \\ -\,3\,7\,\square\,6 \\ \hline 1\,2\,5\,1 \end{array}$$

2

$$\begin{array}{r} 8\,5\,7\,0 \\ -\,4\,3\,1\,1 \\ \hline 4\,\square\,5\,9 \end{array}$$

3

$$\begin{array}{r} 5\,2\,8\,3 \\ +\,4\,0\,1\,2 \\ \hline 9\,2\,9\,\square \end{array}$$

4

$$\begin{array}{r} 3\,6\,5\,1 \\ +\,4\,8\,5\,0 \\ \hline \square\,5\,0\,1 \end{array}$$

5

$$\begin{array}{r} 7\,\square\,8\,5 \\ -\,2\,9\,7\,5 \\ \hline 4\,2\,1\,0 \end{array}$$

6

$$\begin{array}{r} 2\,6\,\square\,3 \\ +\,7\,0\,3\,5 \\ \hline 9\,6\,9\,8 \end{array}$$

Code table

0 = G	1 = O	2 = A	3 = C
4 = F	5 = T	6 = M	8 = H

Check it. Write the letters in order. Do they spell a word? ☐☐☐☐☐☐

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S1-09 (P3-09)

Tables Maze

★ Name _____

Topic: Multiplication and division facts: tables of 6, 7, 8 and 9

Start at START. Move up, down, left or right.
Step only on boxes where the missing number is 6.
Do not step on a box twice.

2 × ? = 12	7 × ? = 42	START 5 × ? = 30	27 ÷ 3 = ?
? × 2 = 10	24 ÷ ? = 4	20 ÷ 5 = ?	? × 2 = 16
? × 5 = 30	? × 8 = 48	24 ÷ ? = 6	FINISH 48 ÷ ? = 8
28 ÷ ? = 7	6 × ? = 36	42 ÷ 7 = ?	? × 4 = 24

Check it. Does your line reach FINISH? Count its boxes: are there 8? Is every missing number 6?

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S1-10 (P3-10)

True or False Tables

★ Name _____

Topic: Multiplication and division facts: tables of 6, 7, 8 and 9

Is each statement true or false?
Circle the letter of the right choice.
Write the six letters in the boxes.

1. 9 groups of 5 is 55. — **True** (K) **False** (P)

2. $7 \times 5 = 42$ — **True** (G) **False** (U)

3. If $7 \times 9 = 63$, then $63 \div 9 = 7$. — **True** (B) **False** (Y)

4. $56 \div 8 = 7$ — **True** (L) **False** (R)

5. 37 is in the 7 times table. — **True** (H) **False** (I)

6. $6 \times 4 = 34$ — **True** (W) **False** (C)

Check it. Write the letters in order.
Do they spell a word?

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S1-11 (P3-11)

Remainders

★ Name _____

Topic: Division with remainder

Divide. Read what is asked.
Write the answer in the box.
Use the code table.

1. Daniel shares 37 cards equally among 6 children. How many are left over?

2. What is the remainder when 63 is divided by 9?

3. 67 cards are put in bags of 5. How many full bags are there?

4. What is the remainder when 67 is divided by 5?

5. 43 beads are packed in boxes of 4. What is the least number of boxes needed?

6. Divide 59 by 8. What is the quotient?

Code table

0 = H	1 = T	2 = I	3 = Q	4 = X
7 = E	8 = U	11 = V	13 = R	

Check it. Write the letters in order. Do they spell a word?

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S1-12 (P3-12)

Fact Families

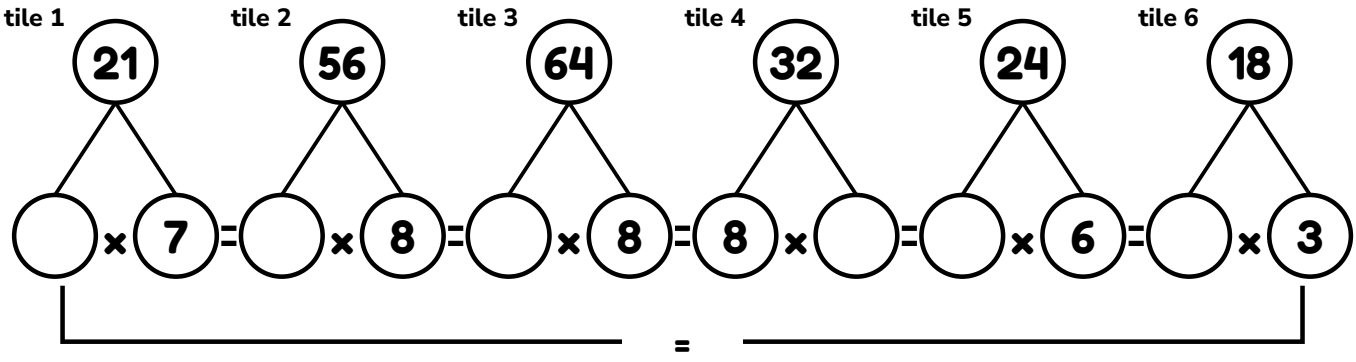
★★ Name _____

Topic: Multiplication and division: finding the missing number, the loop that closes

Find the number in each empty circle.
Touching circles joined by = match.
Go round the loop.

Example
Top 56. Left 7. Right?
56 ÷ 7 = 8. Check: 7 × 8 = 56.

Each tile: top = left × right.



Write the numbers for the empty circles, tile 1 to tile 6.

tile 1	tile 2	tile 3	tile 4	tile 5	tile 6

Check it. Go round the loop. Do the numbers joined by = match?

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S1-13 (P3-13)

Multiply and Divide

★★ Name _____

Topic: Multiplication and division of 3-digit numbers by 1-digit numbers

Work out each sum. Use columns.
Write the answer in the box.
Use the code table.

1

Divide 568 by 8.

2

Divide 318 by 3.

3

$$\begin{array}{r} 219 \\ \times \quad 9 \\ \hline \end{array}$$

4

$$\begin{array}{r} 435 \\ \times \quad 7 \\ \hline \end{array}$$

5

$$\begin{array}{r} 243 \\ \times \quad 8 \\ \hline \end{array}$$

6

Divide 710 by 5.

Code table

71 = F	106 = I	142 = E	1871 = Q	1944 = R
1954 = C	1971 = G	2945 = J	3045 = U	

Check it. Write the letters in order. Do they spell a word?

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S1-14 (P3-14)

Colour the Fish

★★ Name _____

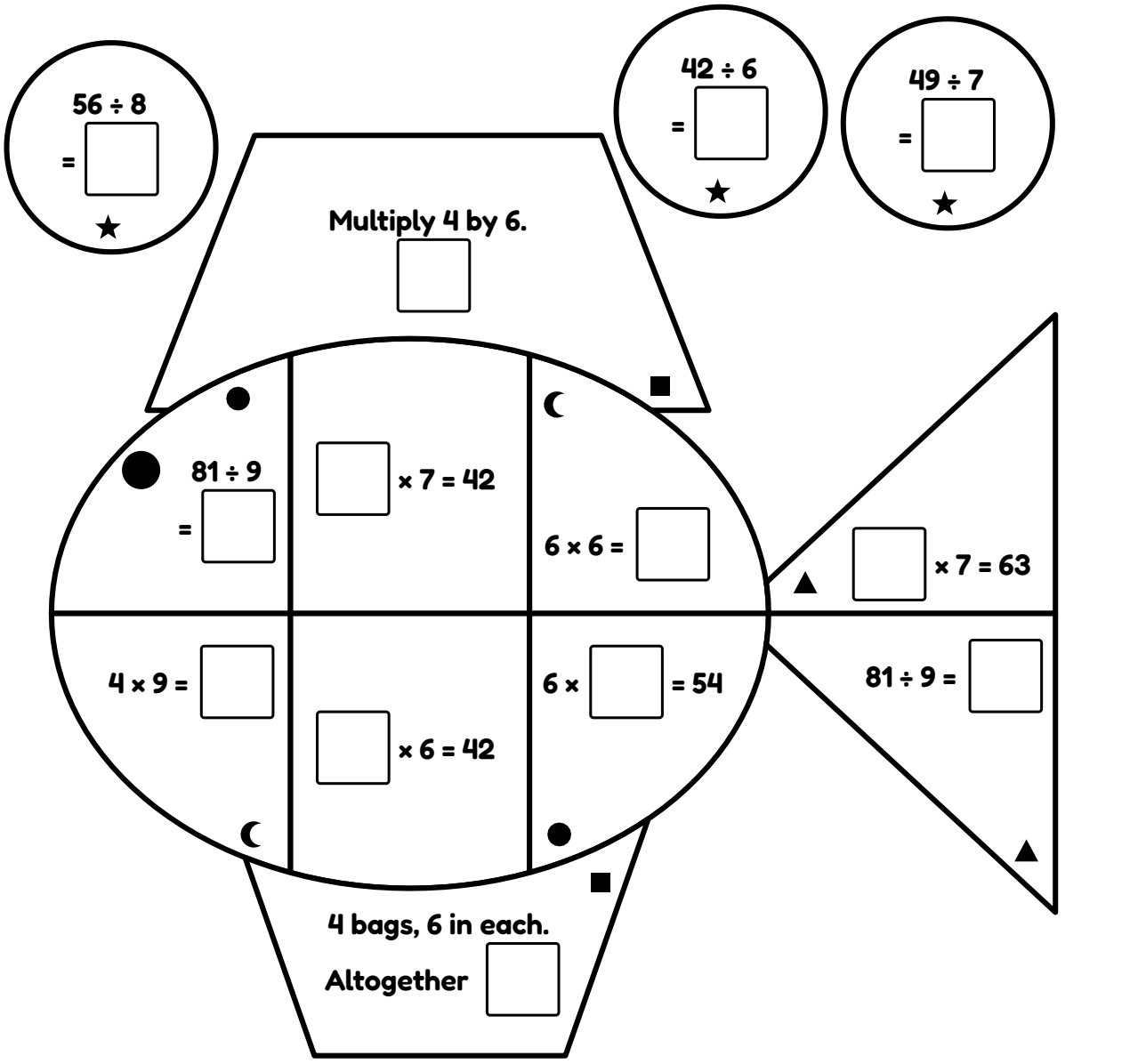
Topic: Multiplication and division: tables of 6, 7, 8 and 9

Work out the answer in each part.

Find it in the key.

Colour the part. No crayon? Write Y, R, B, G or O.

6	7	9	24	36
yellow	red	blue	green	orange



48 ÷ 8 = □	6 × □ = 36	42 ÷ 7 = □

Check it.

Count the parts of each colour. You should have: yellow 4, red 4, blue 4, green 2, orange 2.

Parts with the same small mark have the same colour: ▲ ■ ★ ✚ ● ☾

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S1-15 (P3-15)

Equal Fractions

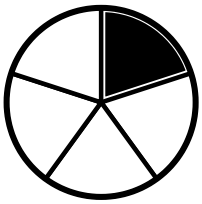
★ Name _____

Topic: Fractions: equivalent fractions

Each shape has equal parts.
Circle the letter of the fraction equal to the shaded part.
Write the six letters in the boxes.

1 

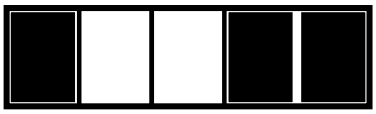
$\frac{4}{10}$ (O) $\frac{4}{9}$ (L) $\frac{4}{8}$ (S)

2 

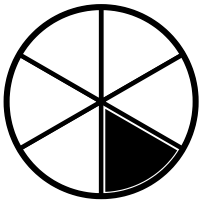
$\frac{2}{9}$ (U) $\frac{2}{10}$ (H) $\frac{2}{11}$ (B)

3 

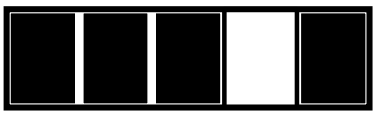
$\frac{3}{10}$ (N) $\frac{3}{9}$ (R) $\frac{6}{9}$ (L)

4 

$\frac{6}{10}$ (I) $\frac{7}{10}$ (D) $\frac{4}{10}$ (V)

5 

$\frac{2}{12}$ (M) $\frac{10}{12}$ (W) $\frac{3}{12}$ (O)

6 

$\frac{2}{10}$ (V) $\frac{8}{10}$ (P) $\frac{8}{9}$ (E)

Check it. Write the letters in order.
Do they spell a word?

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S1-16 (P3-16)

Simplest Form

★ Name _____

Topic: Fractions: simplest form

Start at START. Move up, down, left or right.
Step only on fractions in simplest form.
Do not step on a box twice.

$\frac{2}{6}$	$\frac{1}{4}$	$\frac{3}{6}$	$\frac{3}{9}$
$\frac{4}{5}$	$\frac{3}{10}$	$\frac{1}{10}$	$\frac{4}{9}$
$\frac{6}{11}$	$\frac{8}{12}$	$\frac{5}{10}$	$\frac{7}{8}$
FINISH $\frac{5}{11}$	$\frac{9}{12}$	$\frac{5}{6}$	START $\frac{6}{7}$

Check it. Does your line reach FINISH? Count its boxes: are there 8? Is every fraction in simplest form?

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S1-17 (P3-17)

Fraction Gaps

★★ Name _____

Topic: Fractions: finding an equivalent fraction when the top or bottom number is given

Write the missing number in each box.
The two fractions are equal.
Use the code table.

1 $\frac{5}{6} = \frac{\square}{12}$

2 $\frac{4}{5} = \frac{\square}{10}$

3 $\frac{2}{5} = \frac{\square}{10}$

4 $\frac{3}{6} = \frac{6}{\square}$

5 $\frac{2}{3} = \frac{4}{\square}$

6 $\frac{1}{3} = \frac{3}{\square}$

Code table

4 = P	5 = Y	6 = E	7 = X	8 = O
9 = R	10 = G	11 = Z	12 = H	

Check it. Write the letters in order. Do they spell a word? ☐☐☐☐☐☐

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S1-18 (P3-18)

Fraction Order

★★ Name _____

Topic: Fractions: comparing and ordering unlike fractions

Put each set of fractions in order.
Write the letter of each card in its place.
Set A: smallest first. Set B: greatest first.

Set A: smallest first.

$\frac{11}{12}$	$\frac{2}{3}$	$\frac{3}{4}$
N	J	U

Set B: greatest first.

$\frac{7}{12}$	$\frac{2}{4}$	$\frac{1}{3}$
I	O	R

Write the letters in order: Set A, then Set B.

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

Check it. Read the six letters in order. Do they spell a word?

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S1-19 (P3-19)

Fraction Sums

★★ Name _____

Topic: Fractions: adding and subtracting two related fractions within one whole

Add or subtract the fractions.
The answer's bottom number is printed. Write the top number in the box.
Use the code table.

1 $\frac{2}{4} - \frac{3}{8} = \frac{\square}{8}$

2 $\frac{3}{5} - \frac{1}{10} = \frac{\square}{10}$

3 $\frac{2}{5} + \frac{4}{10} = \frac{\square}{10}$

4 $\frac{2}{5} + \frac{2}{10} = \frac{\square}{10}$

5 $1 - \frac{2}{3} = \frac{\square}{6}$

6 Ben ate $\frac{2}{5}$ of a pizza. Jenny ate $\frac{3}{10}$. What fraction did they eat in all?

$\frac{\square}{10}$

Code table

1 = S	2 = B	3 = P	4 = J
5 = C	6 = I	7 = E	8 = R

Check it. Write the letters in order. Do they spell a word?

☐☐☐☐☐☐

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S1-20 (P3-20)

Money Sums

★ Name _____

Topic: Money: adding and subtracting in dollars and cents

Work out each amount. Write it like this: $3.45.
Use the code table.

1 Mei has $10.40. Mei buys a notebook for $4.70. How much money is left?

$ ☐

2 Wei buys a bag for $4.25 and a scarf for $3.90. How much does Wei pay in all?

$ ☐

3 Zara buys 3 stickers: $4.55, $2.10 and $1.75. How much is the total?

$ ☐

4 A ruler costs $17.30. A cap costs $5.50. How much more does the ruler cost?

$ ☐

5 Lily pays $20.00 for a kite that costs $18.06. How much change does Lily get?

$ ☐

6 How much money is shown?



$ ☐

Code table

$1.94 = T	$5.70 = U	$7.15 = Y	$7.30 = K	$7.40 = J
$7.80 = E	$8.15 = P	$8.40 = D	$11.80 = A	

Check it. Write the letters in order. Do they spell a word? ☐☐☐☐☐☐

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